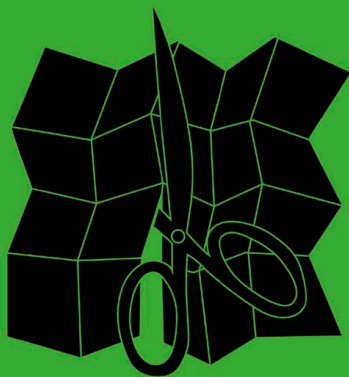




A BOUNDARY FROM POLE TO POLE

THE TREATY OF TORDESILLAS (1494)

IN CONTEXT

FOCUS

International law

BEFORE

2100 BCE The Mesopotamian city-states of Lagash and Umma mark a boundary between them on a stone slab.

387 CE The Peace of Acilisene divides Armenia between the Sassanian Persian and Eastern Roman (Byzantine) empires.

1266 The Treaty of Perth divides jurisdiction over the Northern Isles between Norway and Scotland.

AFTER

1739 By the Treaty of El Pardo, Spain and Britain resolve their dispute about American navigation and trade.

1750 The Treaty of Madrid redraws the boundaries of the Spanish and the Portuguese colonies in South America.

1885 At the Berlin Conference, European leaders divide Africa among themselves.

Portugal and Spain both claim to have **discovered**, and therefore to **own**, new **territories**.



To **avoid a costly war** between these two rival Catholic empires, Pope Alexander VI is asked to **arbitrate**.



The Treaty of Tordesillas **divides the world** into Spanish and Portuguese sectors.

When explorer Christopher Columbus landed in Lisbon, Portugal, on his return from the New World in 1492, he unleashed a centuries-long diplomatic fight between Spain and Portugal, the world's first great colonial powers. Columbus had been sent on his voyage by the joint rulers of Spain, Ferdinand II of Aragon and Isabella I of Castile, but it was the Portuguese king, John II, who was first to hear of the historic discovery.

No European powers at the time considered it relevant that all the regions they “discovered” were already long known and inhabited by Indigenous Peoples. For the new arrivals, “discovery” meant ownership. Portugal, by virtue of its pioneering voyages—its navigators had already explored the coasts of West Africa and India—assumed for itself a natural right to claim “undiscovered” territories. Columbus’s announcement to King